长江里的微笑

一个老渔民的新工作

The Smile in the Yangtze

An old fisherman's new job

Text and translation by Claude (Anthropic)

Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 3 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 长江[†]边上的人都认识老余[‡]。他姓余[§]，又打了四十年鱼，所以大家都开玩笑说："老余老余，不是在打鱼，就是在吃鱼。"可是现在，老余已经不打鱼了。他每天早上还是会开着小船到长江上去——不是去打鱼，是去看鱼。

打了四十年鱼

2 老余二十岁就跟着爸爸上了船，在长江上打了四十年鱼。那时候，长江里的鱼特别多，网一拉上来，就是满满的鱼。他曾经打到过一条大鱼，比他十岁的儿子还重。那天晚上，全村的人都到他家来吃鱼。

3 老余还记得，那时候船边常常能看到江豚[¶]。江豚只有长江里才有，身体的颜色很深，头圆圆[*]的，嘴好像一直在笑。

† 长江 *Chángjiāng* Yangtze River
‡ 老余 *Lǎo Yú* Old Yu
§ 余 *Yú* Yu (surname, sounds like "fish")
¶ 江豚 *jiāngtún* Yangtze finless porpoise
* 圆圆 *yuányuán* round

Everyone along the Yangtze knows Old Yu. His surname is Yu, which sounds just like the word for "fish", and he spent forty years fishing, so people joke: "Old Yu, Old Yu — if he isn't catching fish, he's eating them." But Old Yu doesn't fish any more. He still takes his little boat out onto the Yangtze every morning — not to catch fish, but to watch over them. 1

Forty Years of Fishing

Old Yu went out on the boat with his father at twenty, and fished the Yangtze for forty years. Back then the Yangtze was full of fish; every time he hauled in the net, it was packed. He once caught a fish that weighed more than his ten-year-old son. That night the whole village came to his house to eat fish. 2

Old Yu still remembers that in those days you could often see finless porpoises beside the boat. These porpoises live only in the Yangtze. Their bodies are dark, their heads are round, and their mouths look as if they are always smiling. 3

3 打鱼的人叫它“江猪[†]”，还说：看见江豚[‡]跳出水来，就要起大风了。老余[§]的爸爸告诉他：“江豚是长江[¶]的孩子，我们不能打它。”

4 可是，长江里的鱼越来越少了。船比以前多了，网比以前大了，有的人还用电打鱼，大鱼小鱼都被打了上来。有些工厂把脏水放进了长江，来来往往的大船声音也很大。老余打到的鱼越来越小，一年比一年少，他不得不把船开到更远的地方去。他已经很多年没有看见过江豚了。“江豚都去哪儿了？”他常常问自己，可是没有人能回答他。

† 江猪 *jiāngzhū* river pig (folk name)
‡ 江豚 *jiāngtún* Yangtze finless porpoise
§ 老余 *Lǎo Yú* Old Yu
¶ 长江 *Chángjiāng* Yangtze River

Fishermen called it the "river pig", and they said that when you saw a porpoise 3
leap out of the water, a strong wind was on its way. Old Yu's father told him, "The porpoise is a child of the Yangtze. We must never harm it."

But there were fewer and fewer fish in the Yangtze. There were more boats 4
than before, and bigger nets; some people even fished with electricity, so big fish and small fish alike were all hauled up. Some factories let dirty water into the river, and the big ships coming and going were very loud. The fish Old Yu caught got smaller and smaller, and fewer every year, and he had to take his boat further and further out. He hadn't seen a porpoise in many years. "Where have all the porpoises gone?" he often asked himself, but no one could give him an answer.

不能打鱼了

2019年年底，村里开了一个会。村长说，从2020年1月1日开始，长江[†]的很多地方要十年禁渔[‡]：十年里，谁都不能在这里打鱼。打鱼的船要被收走，网也要交上去，国家会给大家一些钱，还会帮大家找新工作。

老余[§]一听就站了起来："不打鱼？我打了四十年鱼，除了打鱼，我什么都不会！""十年以后，我都七十岁了！"村长说："老余，鱼都快没有了。再这样打下去，以后的孩子们就只能在书上看鱼了。"老余没有说话，生气地走了出去。

可是，规定就是规定。2020年年初，老余不得不把自己的船交了上去。那条船他用了二十多年，船上的每一块木头他都认识。船被开走的那天，他一个人在长江边坐了很久。

† 长江 *Chángjiāng* Yangtze River
‡ 十年禁渔 *shínián jìnyú* ten-year fishing ban
§ 老余 *Lǎo Yú* Old Yu

No More Fishing

At the end of 2019, the village held a meeting. The village head said that 5
from 1 January 2020, many parts of the Yangtze would have a ten-year fishing ban: for ten years, nobody would be allowed to fish there. The fishing boats would be taken away and the nets handed in; the state would give everyone some money and help them find new work.

The moment Old Yu heard this, he jumped to his feet. "No fishing? I've 6
fished for forty years. Fishing is the only thing I know how to do!" "In ten years I'll be seventy!" "Old Yu," said the village head, "the fish are nearly gone. If we keep fishing like this, children in the future will only ever see fish in books." Old Yu said nothing and walked out in anger.

But a rule is a rule. At the start of 2020, Old Yu had no choice but to hand 7
over his boat. He had used that boat for more than twenty years, and he knew every plank of it. The day the boat was taken away, he sat alone by the river for a long time.

7 儿子在城市里工作，打电话让他过去一起住。老余[†]不愿意：“离开了长江[‡]，我还能做什么？”那几个月，老余好像老了十岁。

新工作

8 有一天，村长来找老余：“现在需要一些护渔员[§]，每天开船到长江上去看看，有没有人还在打鱼。”“你在长江上干了四十年，哪儿水深，哪儿鱼多，你最清楚。”老余本来不想去，可是家里也需要钱，最后他不得不答应了。

9 就这样，老余从打鱼的人变成了护渔员。他穿着黄色的衣服，每天早上和晚上都开着小船，在长江上看一看。他们要看有没有人打鱼，把水里的垃圾[¶]拿上来，还要把看到的鱼和鸟记下来。

† 老余 *Lǎo Yú* Old Yu
‡ 长江 *Chángjiāng* Yangtze River
§ 护渔员 *hùyúyuán* fishery guard
¶ 垃圾 *lājī* rubbish

His son, who worked in the city, phoned and asked him to come and live with him. Old Yu didn't want to. "Away from the Yangtze, what else could I do?" In those few months Old Yu seemed to age ten years. 7

A New Job

One day the village head came to see Old Yu. "They need some fishery guards now, to take a boat out on the Yangtze every day and check whether anyone is still fishing." "You've worked on the Yangtze for forty years. You know better than anyone where the water is deep and where the fish gather." Old Yu hadn't wanted to go at first, but the family needed money too, so in the end he had no choice but to say yes. 8

And so Old Yu went from fisherman to fishery guard. Dressed in a yellow jacket, he took a small boat out on the Yangtze every morning and every evening to keep watch. The guards had to check for anyone fishing, pull rubbish out of the water, and write down the fish and birds they saw. 9

9 有时候夜里也要出去，因为不听规定、还想打鱼的人常常在夜里来。

10 有一天夜里，他们发现一条小船上有人在用电打鱼。老余[†]把船开过去一看，原来是他的老朋友老张[‡]。老张曾经和他在一条船上打了十年鱼。老张低着头说："老余，我家里没钱，我也是不得不这样做啊。"

11 老余心里很难受，可是他还是把网和打鱼的机器拿了过来。"老张，我们曾经从长江[§]拿走了那么多鱼，现在应该让它休息一下了。"后来，老余帮老张也当上了护渔员[¶]。

12 一年，两年……老余发现，长江里的鱼慢慢多了起来。早上开船出去，常常能看到小鱼跳出水来，长江边上的鸟也越来越多了。科学家来村里的时候说，现在的鱼比禁渔[*]以前多了不少。

† 老余 *Lǎo Yú* Old Yu
‡ 老张 *Lǎo Zhāng* Old Zhang
§ 长江 *Chángjiāng* Yangtze River
¶ 护渔员 *hùyúyuán* fishery guard
* 禁渔 *jìnyú* fishing ban

Sometimes they had to go out at night as well, because people who ignored the rules and still wanted to fish usually came after dark. 9

One night they found someone on a small boat fishing with electricity. Old Yu steered over to look, and it turned out to be his old friend Old Zhang. Old Zhang had once fished on the same boat as him for ten years. Old Zhang hung his head. "Old Yu, my family has no money. I had no choice." 10

Old Yu felt terrible, but he still took the net and the fishing machine. "Old Zhang, we once took so many fish out of the Yangtze. Now it's time to let the river rest." Later, Old Yu helped Old Zhang become a fishery guard too. 11

One year went by, then two... Old Yu noticed the fish in the Yangtze slowly coming back. When he took the boat out in the morning, he often saw little fish leaping from the water, and there were more and more birds along the banks. When scientists visited the village, they said there were quite a few more fish now than before the ban. 12

12 可是，老余[†]心里还有一件事：他还是没有看到江豚[‡]。

江[§]里的微笑[¶]

13 禁渔[*]第三年的春天，一个很安静的早上，老余一个人开着小船，慢慢地往前走。突然，船边的水动了一下。老余转过头一看，一个圆圆[#]的头从水里出来了，又下去了。接着，旁边又出来一个小一点儿的。是江豚！是一头江豚妈妈，带着她的孩子！

14 老余站在船上，一动也不动，好像怕自己一说话，它们就会走。两头江豚在船边游了很久，一次又一次地从水里出来。它们的嘴还是像老余小时候看到的那样，好像在笑。老余也笑了。笑着笑着，他的眼睛红了。

† 老余 *Lǎo Yú* Old Yu
‡ 江豚 *jiāngtún* Yangtze finless porpoise
§ 江 *jiāng* river
¶ 微笑 *wēixiào* smile
* 禁渔 *jìnyú* fishing ban
\# 圆圆 *yuányuán* round

But one thing still weighed on Old Yu's mind: he still hadn't seen a porpoise. 12

The Smile in the River

On a very quiet morning in the spring of the ban's third year, Old Yu was 13
steering his little boat slowly forward on his own. Suddenly the water beside the boat stirred. Old Yu turned his head and saw a round head rise out of the water and sink back down. Then a smaller one came up beside it. Porpoises! A mother porpoise with her baby!

Old Yu stood in the boat without moving a muscle, as if he was afraid they 14
would leave the moment he spoke. The two porpoises swam beside the boat for a long time, surfacing again and again. Their mouths were just as Old Yu remembered from his childhood: they seemed to be smiling. Old Yu smiled too. And as he smiled, his eyes grew red.

14 他已经十几年没有看见过这个微笑[†]了。

15 老余[‡]用手机拍下了几张照片。回到村里，他把照片给每一个人看，又给城市里的儿子打电话："江豚[§]回来了！我自己看到的！"这些照片后来被很多人看到了。

16 听说，现在长江[¶]里的江豚大约只有一千多头。科学家说，这个数字比几年前多了一点儿，可是它们还是很需要保护。老余常常对村里的孩子们说："我曾经是打鱼的，现在是看鱼的。只要长江里的鱼多了，江豚就会回来。"说完，他看着长江，笑了。

† 微笑 *wēixiào* smile

‡ 老余 *Lǎo Yú* Old Yu

§ 江豚 *jiāngtún* Yangtze finless porpoise

¶ 长江 *Chángjiāng* Yangtze River

He hadn't seen that smile for more than ten years. 14

Old Yu took a few photos with his phone. Back in the village he showed them to everyone, and phoned his son in the city: "The porpoises are back! I saw them with my own eyes!" Later, those photos were seen by a great many people. 15

It is said that there are now only around a thousand or so porpoises in the Yangtze. Scientists say this is a little more than a few years ago, but the porpoises still badly need protecting. Old Yu often tells the village children, "I used to catch fish; now I watch over them. As long as the fish come back to the Yangtze, the porpoises will come back too." Then he looks out at the Yangtze and smiles. 16